

too. What probably helped him stay sane through the trouble I was causing him was that my brother Satish and sister Anju were shaping up well academically.

Within a month of the alcohol episode, Bauji sold off the flat in Bhandup, and we moved into a rented house in Dombivli. I was halfway through my last school year, but Bauji had decided that I was not to set foot in Bhandup so long as he could help it. Using some connections, he managed to get me admission in the South Indian Association High School in Dombivli West.

Our moving house caused more inconvenience to my father than to me, since he now had to commute more than half an hour in a crowded local train to reach his factory, whereas previously it took him less than ten minutes by a BEST bus.

The new school was not to my liking, but I had little say in the matter. An overwhelming majority of the students were south Indian, and so were the staff. There was a bully or two in every class, and some *mawaali* types as well, but they were a far cry from the Shankars and Arthurs I had got to know so well.

I was slow when it came to making new friends, and perhaps that helped me focus on my studies. I scored 71 per cent in my SSC, which even in those days was not good enough to ensure admission to the science course in any of the reputed colleges. Not that I was keen on taking up Science, but it had been my father's dream to see me become an engineer. But by now Bauji too had realized he would not be able to pay the hefty donations that almost every decent engineering college – barring the top two or three – demanded. He had some money left from the sale of our Bhandup house, but it was too much of a gamble for him to stake that money on my academic career.

So that Bauji did not nurse any false hopes for me and set himself up for further disappointment, I confessed to him that I lacked the aptitude for science and would be more comfortable studying commerce, or any of the arts subjects.

He did not try to change my mind, and after consulting some friends and relatives, advised me to take up commerce. Truth be told, Bauji's decision to shift to Dombivli was not a sound one. It could have easily backfired on him but for an unexpected twist of events.

Because of massive real estate development in the suburb, Dombivli soon became a thriving ground for thugs and other antisocial elements. Street